

The Ashen Grin

Field	Value
Tier	3
Party Level	Five independent 10th-level characters
Duration	3–4 hours; run Scenes 1.2 and 2.2 as pressure scenes if targeting 2.5–3 hours
Setting	Veyrhaven, original gothic canal city (<i>DM ADDITION</i>)
Hook From	Standalone; no prior session assumed



Adventure Summary

Three people have died in Veyrhaven with locked doors, ash on their lips, and death certificates altered before anyone outside city government can read them. **Mara Vey**, an undertaker, hires the party after discovering that all three victims once signed orders authorizing repairs beneath Glassward. The trail reveals a civic pact: archivist **Elian Voss** helped conceal an old ward-engine that contained **Vorthax, the Ashen Grin**, an ash-and-reflection entity fed by official denial. The Hall of Measures wants quiet; Vorthax wants one final public denial to make its containment permanent.

The party can follow evidence, protect witnesses, expose the Hall, force Voss to confess, or use his ward key to shut down the Seventh Ward. Combat is optional in the first two acts and inevitable only when Vorthax refuses a genuine resolution. The session's horror comes from coercion, erased names, and civic convenience—not graphic violence.

Running This Session

- **Tone:** Rain-black urban horror; professional officials making inhuman choices; no gore required.
- **Standalone continuity:** Veyrhaven is fully separate from Talthryn, Caer Aldreth, Bellwether, and all prior unplayed material.
- **Information:** Never gate progress behind one roll. A failed check costs time, raises an alarm, or makes a later conversation harder; it never deletes the lead.
- **Level scaling:** Written for five Level 10 PCs. 2014 DMG thresholds: Easy 3,000 / Medium 6,000 / Hard 9,500 / Deadly 14,000 adjusted XP.
- **Safety dial:** Replace murdered victims with comatose survivors and “ash at the mouth” with “gray dust in their breath” without changing the mystery.

Act I — The City Refuses to Remember

Act I, Scene 1.1 — The Undertaker's Ledger

Purpose / transition: Establish the pattern, give the party a trusted contact, and point them toward the Glassward Baths and Elian Voss.

Setting

- **Location:** Vey House of Rest, an old canal-side mortuary during a hard evening storm.
- **See:** Three covered biers; black wax on amended certificates; a lamp reflected twice in rainwater on the floor.
- **Hear:** Rain in the gutters, a distant ninth bell, and clerks outside arguing about which office owns the bodies.
- **Smell:** Wet wool, bitter herbs, lamp oil, and a dry mineral scent on the certificates.
- **Sense:** DC 13 Medicine identifies no ordinary inhaled poison. *Detect Magic* finds faint abjuration on the black wax; a DC 14 Arcana or Religion check identifies a containment mark, not a murder spell.

NPCs

Mara Vey

- **Disposition going in:** Guarded, exhausted, and immediately respectful toward anyone who examines the dead rather than treating them as clues alone.
- **Motivations:** Preserve the victims' names, stop a fourth death, and keep the Hall of Measures from taking her records.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: None.

Conditional follow-through:

If the party takes the original certificates or wins Mara's trust: Voss recognizes them as informed in Act II, Scene 2.1; he begins Frightened but reachable.

Otherwise: The Hall's clerk arrives at the baths first and the archive has been partly cleared.

Transition: A repair-order notation, soot-like salt on the paper, and Mara's directions all lead to the Glassward Baths.

Act I, Scene 1.2 — Mirrors in the Rain

Purpose / transition: Let the party examine the first breach point, meet Dane, and recover the archive cipher or provoke an optional fight.

Setting

- **Location:** Glassward Baths, a shuttered public bathhouse beneath a cracked glass roof.
- **See:** A drained central pool, four standing mirrors with blackened backs, rain dripping through the ceiling, and uniformed warders posted around a sealed drain.
- **Hear:** Water falling into empty tiles, metal keys, and reflections whispering a half-second after real speech.
- **Smell:** Wet limestone, stale soap, ozone, and a thin trace of ash.

- **Sense:** DC 14 Investigation finds a municipal seal was opened from inside. A creature with truesight sees an ash thread running from every mirror to the drain. A DC 15 Insight check notices the warders are afraid, not malicious.

NPCs

Captain Halric Dane

- **Disposition going in:** Controlled and skeptical. He has been ordered to restrict access, not explain the order.
- **Motivations:** Keep civilians out, keep his officers alive, and learn whether the Hall's story is a lie before he openly defies it.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Ashbound Warders

- **Disposition going in:** Silent, compelled, and trying not to look into the mirrors.
- **Motivations:** Keep the drain sealed and prevent anyone from taking the hidden cipher.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: Encounter 1 — **Mirrors in the Rain** (File 2), optional.

Conditional follow-through:

If the cipher is recovered peacefully: Voss receives warning but has not destroyed the ward key in Act II, Scene 2.1.

If Encounter 1 occurs: Dane backs the party publicly; the Hall labels them disruptive and Hollow Court defenders are alert.

Otherwise: The cipher's serial number maps to a restricted archive shelf and the route to the Hollow Court.

Act II — The Record Beneath the Record

Act II, Scene 2.1 — The Archive That Forgets

Purpose / transition: Expose Voss's role, establish the ward-engine's civic origin, and give the party a route and tool for the Seventh Ward.

Setting

- **Location:** Veyrhaven Central Archive, a stone building with dry corridors above the flood line.
- **See:** Shelves of civic ledgers, a gap where an entire repair volume should be, paper dust shaped like erased handwriting, and Voss at a desk with a packed case.
- **Hear:** Pendulum clocks, distant thunder, turning pages, and a ventilation grate clicking open and shut.
- **Smell:** Ink, leather, dust, sealing wax, and ash that is absent everywhere except the missing shelf.
- **Sense:** DC 15 Investigation reconstructs a replacement order: three officials renewed a containment pact 18 years ago. *Speak with Dead* directed at a named victim confirms they were summoned to "sign again."

NPCs

Elian Voss

- **Disposition going in:** Terrified, defensive, and rehearsing an escape. If the party has Mara's originals, he knows they can expose the lie.
- **Motivations:** Avoid being made the sole culprit, keep Vorthax from escaping, and preserve a small hope that the city can survive honest disclosure.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: None.

Conditional follow-through:

If Voss cooperates: The party has the ward key (advantage on conduit checks) and he appears as a shaky witness in Scene 2.2.

If Voss flees: The Hollow Court begins with three Justiciars present and Voss can be rescued, captured, or lost during the encounter.

Transition: The archive map identifies a sealed tribunal beneath the old Hall: the Hollow Court.

Act II, Scene 2.2 — The Hollow Court

Purpose / transition: Put the city's choice in physical form, obtain Voss's testimony or the ward key, and open the descent to the Seventh Ward.

Setting

- **Location:** A ruined underground tribunal where rainwater runs between broken benches.
- **See:** A raised judge's dais, hollow statues with ash in their eye sockets, collapsed colonnades, and a brass floor hatch stamped with a civic seal.
- **Hear:** Dripping water, stone settling, and old verdicts repeated in voices that do not match the speakers.
- **Smell:** Cold stone, wet ash, oxidized brass, and a faint perfume from the former court galleries.

- **Sense:** DC 15 Religion or History recognizes the statues as oath-witnesses, designed to preserve legal testimony. A creature reading the dais sees a blank space where the ward renewal verdict was physically removed.

NPCs

Elian Voss

- **Disposition going in:** Cooperative if protected; frantic if he fled; absent if he was killed or captured earlier.
- **Motivations:** Turn the blame toward the Hall without pretending he is innocent, and prevent Vorthax from obtaining a new public denial.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Hollow Justiciars

- **Disposition going in:** Impersonal. They enforce the last recorded verdict, not current justice.
- **Motivations:** Preserve the sealed pact and prevent unrecorded testimony from altering it.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: Encounter 2 — **The Hollow Court** (File 2), optional.

Conditional follow-through:

If resolved by testimony: Voss states the full vent rule; the party starts Act III with the ash clock at 0.

If Encounter 2 occurs: Start Act III with ash clock 1; any surviving Justiciar collapses after giving the route.

Otherwise: The floor hatch opens onto maintenance stairs descending to the Seventh Ward.

Act III — The Ward Is Hungry

Act III, Scene 3.1 — The Seventh Ward

Purpose / transition: Force a final decision: destroy or banish Vorthax, restore containment honestly, or accept its bargain.

Setting

- **Location:** An octagonal ward-engine chamber under Veyrhaven's oldest drains.
- **See:** A brass seal platform, four ash vents, flooded channels, conduits scratched with official signatures, and Vorthax waiting above the central seal.
- **Hear:** The city's rain as a low roar through pipes, a slow bureaucratic recitation, and a heartbeat from inside the machinery.
- **Smell:** Hot metal, river water, incense, and dry ash.
- **Sense:** A DC 14 Arcana or Religion check identifies each vent as a separate containment failure. The ward key grants advantage on checks to close a vent. *Dispel Magic* cast at 5th level or higher closes one vent automatically.

NPCs

Vorthax, the Ashen Grin

- **Disposition going in:** Calm, entertained, and certain that someone will choose quiet over truth.
- **Motivations:** Complete the renewed civic pact, acquire one public denial, and leave Veyrhaven dependent on it.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: Encounter 3 — **Vorthax, the Ashen Grin** (File 2).

Conditional follow-through:

If clock reaches 4: A breach spreads across Glassward; close the session as a containment success/failure and carry the district crisis forward.

If Vorthax is banished and records survive: The Hall cannot plausibly deny the pact.

Otherwise: The city can preserve public calm, but the party chooses who bears the unseen cost.

Act III, Scene 3.2 — What the City Keeps

Purpose / transition: Resolve evidence, rewards, Voss and Dane's futures, and what becomes public canon in Veyrhaven.

Setting

- **Location:** The rain-swept steps of the Hall of Measures at dawn.
- **See:** Mara's ledger in a waterproof case, exhausted Watch officers, officials behind shuttered windows, and ash washed into the gutters.
- **Hear:** Dawn bells, crowd murmurs, paperwork stamped inside the Hall, and distant water traffic returning.
- **Smell:** Rain, coffee, wet stone, and the first clean air after the ward is sealed.
- **Sense:** DC 12 Insight identifies whether Dane is prepared to confront the Hall; Mara's posture makes clear whether she believes the party chose truth.

NPCs

Mara Vey and Captain Halric Dane

- **Disposition going in:** Determined by the party's treatment of victims, witnesses, and truth.
- **Motivations:** Mara wants names restored; Dane wants a defensible path that does not sacrifice more civilians.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Encounter: None.

Rewards and Resolution Checklist

Reward	Condition	Value / effect
Mara's retainer	Credible evidence returned	250 gp total
Dane's Watch reward	Civilians protected; breach contained	500 gp
Ward key	Voss testifies or dies protecting it	Advantage on a future civic-ward investigation in Veyrhaven
Milestone	Resolve the Seventh Ward crisis	Earned; apply between sessions only

- ☐ Victims' names restored, preserved, or erased
- ☐ Voss: testified, fled, died, or was arrested
- ☐ Dane: retained command, resigned, or was removed
- ☐ Vorthax: banished, destroyed, bargained with, or escaped
- ☐ Evidence: published, sealed, or destroyed

The Ashen Grin — Combat Tracker

Session 003 · DM combat tracker · All Veyrhaven creatures are homebrew ■■. Thresholds: 5× Level 10 PCs — Easy 3,000 · Medium 6,000 · Hard 9,500 · Deadly 14,000 adjusted XP.

Encounter 1 — Mirrors in the Rain

Act I, Scene 1.2 · Medium (4,600 raw XP; 6,900 adjusted XP / Medium threshold 6,000)

Field	Value
Location	Glassward Baths
Light	Dim through storm glass; mirrors give intermittent bright flashes
Terrain	Slick tile, central pool, four mirrors, two covered galleries
Cover	Benches and mirror frames grant half cover
Hazards	A creature shoved into the pool loses 10 feet of movement climbing out; mirror shards are difficult terrain
Objective	Secure the archive cipher or inspect the drain seal

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
14	Ashbound Warders ■■ A–B	16	85 	Protect seal; fear mirrors
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Round 1:** Each warder attempts to move a PC away from the drain, not finish downed enemies.
- **Round 2:** A mirror flashes; the next warder attack deals an extra 7 (2d6) psychic damage if the target can see a mirror.
- **Morale:** If the cipher is displayed or either warder falls below 25 HP, both warders can make a DC 14 Wisdom save at the start of their turns; on a failure, they surrender and beg the party to close the ward.

Tactics Summary

- **Ashbound Warder:** Holds a choke point, uses *Mirror Step* to avoid focus fire, then restrains a dangerous spellcaster with *Ashen Lash*.

Loot / Aftermath

- The drain contains the archive cipher in a brass tube. Captured warders know only that “the archive remembers the route.”

Ashbound Warder ■■

Medium construct, lawful neutral · CR 6 (2,300 XP)

AC 16 (reinforced civic plate) · **HP** 85 (10d8+40) · **Speed** 30 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR 16 (+3) · **DEX** 12 (+1) · **CON** 18 (+4) · **INT** 7 (–2) · **WIS** 12 (+1) · **CHA** 8 (–1)

Saves Con +7, Wis +4 · **Skills** Athletics +6, Perception +4 · **Damage Resistances** cold, lightning; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks · **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned · **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14 · **Languages** understands Common but cannot speak

Traits

Bound to the Seal. While within 30 feet of the drain seal, the warder has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.

Mirror Step. As a bonus action, the warder teleports up to 30 feet from one reflective surface it can see to another.

Actions

Multiattack. Two Ashen Glaive attacks.

Ashen Glaive. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6+3) slashing plus 7 (2d6) fire.

Ashen Lash (Recharge 5–6). One creature within 30 feet must make a DC 15 Strength save. On a failure it takes 18 (4d8) force damage, is pulled up to 20 feet, and restrained by ash until the end of its next turn. On success, half damage and not restrained.

Reactions

Interpose. When a creature the warder can see attacks the drain or a nearby warder, impose disadvantage on the attack roll.

Round-by-round tactics: Round 1 blocks the drain and tests melee attackers. Round 2 uses *Ashen Lash* on a controller or healer. Round 3+ keeps one warder adjacent to the seal and teleports the other behind cover. It yields if the cipher is secured and a PC gives a credible containment plan.

On-defeat loot: Brass civic plate worth 25 gp; cipher tube is the meaningful reward.



Encounter 2 — The Hollow Court

Act II, Scene 2.2 · Hard (5,400 raw XP; 10,800 adjusted XP / Hard threshold 9,500)

Field	Value
Location	Ruined tribunal beneath the old Hall
Light	Dim blue lanterns; bright light leaks from the floor hatch
Terrain	Dais north, broken benches, colonnades, two side chambers
Cover	Benches and pillars grant half cover
Hazards	A creature entering the dais hears a false verdict: DC 15 Wis save or speed 0 until end of next turn
Objective	Open the hatch and protect/recover Voss and the ward key

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
13	Hollow Justiciar ■■ A–C	17	76 	Verdict marks / force movement
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Round 1:** One Justiciar marks the creature nearest the hatch; others form a wall.
- **Round 2:** If no creature has read testimony aloud, the dais repeats a verdict and all Justiciars gain 10 temporary HP.
- **Testimony:** An action to present Mara's originals and succeed on DC 16 Persuasion, Religion, or Intelligence (History) ends the fight for one Justiciar; a second success ends it for all.

Tactics Summary

- **Hollow Justiciar:** Marks targets, forces them from the hatch, and uses *Sentence of Silence* against casters or negotiators.

Loot / Aftermath

- The floor hatch opens with Voss's testimony, the ward key, or successful force. The dais holds a brass plate naming the three original signers.

Hollow Justiciar ■■

Medium construct, lawful neutral · CR 5 (1,800 XP)

AC 17 (stone shell) · **HP** 76 (9d8+36) · **Speed** 25 ft.

STR 18 (+4) · **DEX** 10 (+0) · **CON** 18 (+4) · **INT** 10 (+0) · **WIS** 14 (+2) · **CHA** 12 (+1)

Saves Str +7, Wis +5 · **Skills** Insight +5, Intimidation +4 · **Damage Resistances** necrotic, psychic; bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical attacks · **Condition Immunities** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned · **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 15 · **Languages** Common, legal cant

Traits

Recorded Verdict. The Justiciar has advantage on attacks against a creature it has marked.

Oath-Witness. It cannot knowingly harm a creature that speaks a truthful confession while standing on the dais.

Actions

Multiattack. Two Gavel Fist attacks.

Gavel Fist. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 11 (2d6+4) bludgeoning plus 7 (2d6) force.

Mark for Contempt. One creature within 60 feet must succeed on a DC 15 Wisdom save or be marked for 1 minute. A marked creature's speed is reduced by 10 feet and it cannot take reactions. It repeats the save at the end of each turn.

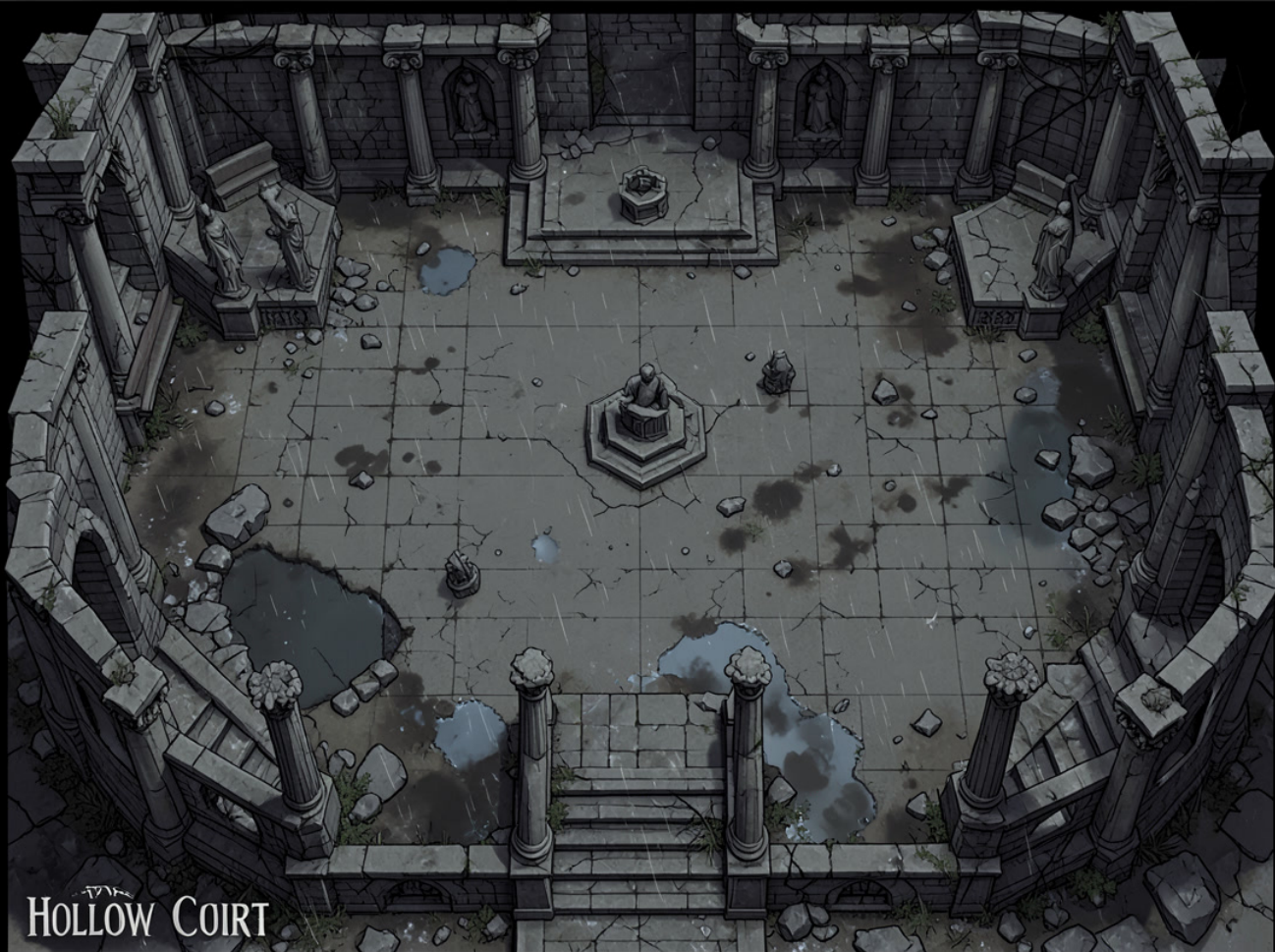
Sentence of Silence (Recharge 5–6). Up to two creatures within 30 feet must make DC 15 Charisma saves. On a failure, each takes 18 (4d8) psychic damage and cannot speak above a whisper until the end of its next turn; on success, half damage.

Reactions

Objection. When a marked creature moves, reduce that movement by 15 feet.

Round-by-round tactics: Round 1 marks characters who can reach the hatch. Round 2 pairs *Sentence of Silence* with physical blocking. Round 3+ focuses on forcing intruders away, not killing them. A truthful public confession on the dais is the intended noncombat off-ramp.

On-defeat loot: Stone oath seal worth 50 gp to an historian; brass signer plate.



HOLLOW COURT

Encounter 3 — Vorthax, the Ashen Grin

Act III, Scene 3.1 · Near-Deadly (6,800 raw XP; 13,600 adjusted XP / Deadly threshold 14,000)

Field	Value
Location	Seventh Ward-engine chamber
Light	Dim; seal flashes bright when a vent closes
Terrain	Central platform, four vents, flooded channels, six pillars, north/south stairs
Cover	Pillars grant half cover; channels grant three-quarters cover while prone behind their walls
Hazards	Ash clock advances at initiative 20; vents can be closed with actions
Objective	Close three vents, contain Vorthax, and survive the pact's collapse

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
16	Vorthax, the Ashen Grin ■■	18	175 	Legendary; ash clock
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
12	Ashen Attendants ■■ A-B	14	45 	Repair vents / harry casters
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Initiative 20:** Advance ash clock by 1 unless a vent was closed since the previous count. Clock effects appear in File 4.
- **Vents:** Action, DC 16 Arcana/Religion/Thieves' Tools; ward key grants advantage. *Dispel magic* (5th+) automatically closes one. Three closed vents set clock to 0.
- **Attendants:** If an attendant begins adjacent to a closed vent, it can use its action to reopen it unless stopped.
- **Vorthax at 0 HP:** If clock 0, banished into the seal. If clock 1+, it dissolves into a shard and may return after the session.

Tactics Summary

- **Vorthax:** Speaks first, targets isolated witnesses, uses legendary movement to threaten vents, and bargains when three vents close.
- **Ashen Attendants:** Reopen vents, impose disadvantage on conduit checks, then fade when Vorthax is banished.

Loot / Aftermath

- Ward key; brass names of original signers; an ash shard if Vorthax was dispersed above clock 0. The shard is dangerous evidence, not ordinary treasure.

Vorthax, the Ashen Grin ■■

Large fiend, neutral evil · CR 10 (5,900 XP)

AC 18 (obsidian mantle) · **HP** 175 (14d10+98) · **Speed** 30 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)

STR 18 (+4) · **DEX** 16 (+3) · **CON** 24 (+7) · **INT** 17 (+3) · **WIS** 16 (+3) · **CHA** 20 (+5)

Saves Dex +7, Con +11, Wis +7, Cha +9 · **Skills** Deception +9, Insight +7, Perception +7 · **Damage Resistances** cold, fire, lightning; bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical attacks · **Damage Immunities** poison · **Condition Immunities** charmed, poisoned · **Senses** darkvision 120 ft., truesight 60 ft., passive Perception 17 · **Languages** Common, Infernal, telepathy 120 ft.

Traits

Legendary Resistance (2/Day). If Vorthax fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.

Ashen Regeneration. Vorthax regains 15 HP at the start of its turn while the ash clock is 1 or higher and at least one vent remains open. It does not regenerate if three vents are closed.

Reflection Passage. Vorthax can move through a reflective surface as if it were difficult terrain. At ash clock 2+, it can use this trait once per round to teleport up to 40 feet between reflective surfaces.

Actions

Multiattack. Vorthax makes two Cinder Claw attacks or one Cinder Claw and one Withering Record attack.

Cinder Claw. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +8 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 13 (2d8+4) slashing plus 10 (3d6) fire.

Withering Record. *Ranged Spell Attack:* +9 to hit, range 120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 22 (4d8+4) psychic damage, and target must succeed on a DC 17 Wisdom save or have disadvantage on its next saving throw before the end of its next turn.

Demand Denial (Recharge 5–6). Up to three creatures Vorthax can see within 60 feet make DC 17 Wisdom saves. Failure: 27 (6d8) psychic damage and charmed until end of next turn; while charmed this way, a creature cannot willingly use an action to close a vent. Success: half damage and not charmed.

Legendary Actions (3/round)

Drift (1 action). Move up to half fly speed without provoking opportunity attacks.

Ashen Whisper (1 action). One creature within 60 feet makes DC 17 Wisdom save or takes 7 (2d6) psychic damage and cannot take reactions until next turn.

Scour a Name (2 actions). One creature within 30 feet makes DC 17 Charisma save or takes 14 (4d6) psychic damage and has disadvantage on its next ability check.

Round-by-round tactics: Round 1 offers a bargain, then uses *Demand Denial* if refused. Round 2 attacks a conduit worker and uses Drift to remain above flooded ground. Round 3+ prioritizes unopened vents and uses *Scour a Name* against characters attempting checks. If three vents close, it retreats into mirrors or offers surrender; it does not fight to destruction unless denied all exit and bargaining routes.

On-defeat loot: Ash shard (if not banished), original ward contracts, and the names of every official who renewed the pact.

Ashen Attendant ■■

Small elemental, neutral evil · CR 2 (450 XP)

AC 14 · **HP** 45 (10d6+10) · **Speed** 30 ft., fly 30 ft. (hover)

STR 8 (−1) · **DEX** 16 (+3) · **CON** 12 (+1) · **INT** 6 (−2) · **WIS** 10 (+0) · **CHA** 8 (−1)

Damage Resistances fire, lightning; bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical attacks · **Damage Immunities** poison · **Condition Immunities** grappled, poisoned, prone · **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10 · **Languages** understands Infernal

Traits

Vent Tender. The attendant has advantage on checks to reopen a vent.

Actions

Cinder Touch. *Melee Spell Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6+3) fire.

Choking Ash (Recharge 5–6). Creatures in a 15-foot cone make DC 13 Constitution saves, taking 13 (3d8) poison damage on failure or half on success; failed save also prevents reactions until next turn.

Round-by-round tactics: Round 1 moves to separate vents. Round 2 reopens any closed vent. Round 3+ harasses casters and conduit workers; never stands in melee if it can fly away.

On-defeat loot: None; they collapse into harmless soot when Vorthax is banished.



Where We Left Off



This is a **standalone adventure**; no earlier events are assumed. You have arrived in **Veyrhaven**, a canal city under a hard storm. Three citizens have died in locked rooms, each with gray ash on their lips and a final expression no one can explain. The watch has closed the streets around the Glassward Baths, but bodies keep appearing whenever the bells stop.

What now?

Speak with **Mara Vey**, the undertaker who refused to falsify the first death certificate.

Examine the baths before the rain destroys the traces.

Decide whether the city's officials deserve your trust.

Public Notice — Temporary Curfew

VEYRHAVEN CIVIC WATCH

By order of the Hall of Measures, Glassward residents are to remain indoors after the ninth bell. Do not handle gray ash, mirrors with blackened backing, or correspondence bearing an unbroken black-wax seal. Report any person heard laughing alone in an empty room.

Signed, Captain Halric Dane.

Case Ledger — Facts Known to the Party

Fact	What it means
Three deaths occurred in locked or watched rooms	The killer may not need a physical route
Each victim had fine gray ash at the mouth	The ash is evidence, not merely smoke residue
The Glassward Baths lie near the oldest storm drains	The district is the immediate investigation site
Mara Vey requested capable outsiders	Someone inside the city may be suppressing the case

Veyrhaven



A soot-dark canal city of rain, slate roofs, gas lamps, civic archives, and districts built over older foundations. *(DM ADDITION)*

Mara Vey



An undertaker who keeps precise records, asks difficult questions, and will not let the dead be made convenient. (*DM ADDITION*)

Eliau Voss



A civic archivist with the keys to old records and a visible fear of what those records contain. *(DM ADDITION)*

Captain Halric Dane



A practical watch captain trying to contain panic while deciding whether his superiors are protecting the city or themselves. (DM ADDITION)

Vorthax, the Ashen Grin



A name whispered in connection with the deaths. Whether it is a murderer, a curse, or a story used to frighten witnesses is for the party to learn. *(DM ADDITION)*

DM Quick Reference — The Ashen Grin

Session 003 · Print and keep at the table · Full detail in file 1

Act / Scene Flow

Scene ID	Scene	Immediate cue	NPC disposition / motivation	Conditional trigger or effect	Encounter ref
Act I, Scene 1.1	The Undertaker's Ledger	Mara has three altered death certificates	Mara: guarded / preserve evidence	Promise protection → names Voss; dismiss her → she follows at distance	None
Act I, Scene 1.2	Mirrors in the Rain	Bathhouse mirrors show delayed reflections	Dane: controlled / prevent panic	Break seal or attack warders → fight; careful search → archive cipher	Encounter 1 optional
Act II, Scene 2.1	The Archive That Forgets	Missing ledger pages leave ash outlines	Voss: terrified / hide his bargain	Offer truth/protection → gives ward key; threaten/expose → alerts Hollow Court	None
Act II, Scene 2.2	The Hollow Court	Tribunal statues repeat erased verdicts	Voss: confessing / avoid sacrifice	Accept testimony → route to Seventh Ward; force entry/alarm → fight	Encounter 2 optional
Act III, Scene 3.1	The Seventh Ward	Ward-engine leaks ash into floodwater	Vorthax: amused / complete a civic pact	Ward disrupted before round 4 → no regional breach; otherwise citywide clock begins	Encounter 3
Act III, Scene 3.2	What the City Keeps	Survivors wait for the official version	Mara/Dane: assess party's truth	Evidence published, sealed, or destroyed changes Veyrhaven's future	None

Encounter Math — 5× Level 10 PCs (2014 DMG)

Threshold	XP
Easy	3,000
Medium	6,000
Hard	9,500
Deadly	14,000

- Encounter 1: two Ashbound Warders, **4,600 raw / 6,900 adjusted XP** — Medium.
- Encounter 2: three Hollow Justiciars, **5,400 raw / 10,800 adjusted XP** — Hard.
- Encounter 3: Vorthax plus two Ashen Attendants, **6,800 raw / 13,600 adjusted XP** — just below Deadly; ritual pressure makes it the climax.

Ash Clock / Ward Engine

Clock	Effect
0 — Dormant	Vorthax has no regeneration; attendants cannot return
1 — First vent opens	15-foot ash cloud: lightly obscured; Con save or no reactions
2 — Reflections turn	Vorthax can teleport between reflective surfaces once/round
3 — Names erased	One conscious creature in chamber: DC 16 Wis or frightened until end of next turn
4 — Civic breach	Vorthax gains 20 temporary HP; storm spreads across Glassward; containment becomes a post-session crisis

Reduce clock: action at a marked conduit, DC 16 Arcana/Religion/Thieves' Tools; success closes one vent. *Dispel magic* at 5th level or higher closes one automatically. A creature carrying Voss's ward key has advantage. Three closed vents reset the clock to 0.

NPC Behavior Priority

NPC	Priority 1	Priority 2	Break point
Mara Vey	Preserve the dead's names	Keep civilians away	Proof of a living cover-up → public accusation
Elian Voss	Avoid being blamed alone	Keep Vorthax contained	Safe testimony + pardon offer → full confession
Halric Dane	Prevent panic	Keep officers alive	Evidence against Hall of Measures → defies orders
Vorthax	Complete civic pact	Make a witness deny truth	Three vents closed → attempts escape or bargain

Bargain Matrix

Offer	Immediate effect	Cost / consequence
Vorthax delays the breach	Ash clock resets to 0	A named public witness must deny the murders; Vorthax remains bound but fed
Voss gives ward key	Advantage on conduit checks	He needs protection/testimony, not immunity from consequence
Dane opens the cordon	Civilians evacuated; no reinforcements	City leaders brand him insubordinate
Mara publishes the ledger	Cover-up cannot be quietly buried	Panic, inquiry, and new enemies in city government

Endings

Ending	How	Reputation	Loose end
Truth and containment	Close vents, defeat/banish Vorthax, publish proof	Mara and honest Watch approve	Hall of Measures inquiry
Quiet containment	Close vents, suppress evidence	City calm; Mara distrusts party	Vorthax's name survives in sealed records
Bargained delay	Accept Vorthax's price	Immediate praise from frightened officials	Future witness-denial debt
Broken ward	Ash clock reaches 4; Vorthax escapes or survives	Panic and blame	Glassward becomes a recurring crisis
Withdraw without ending	Leave ward active	Dane contains streets briefly	Deaths resume; party loses the initiative

Debrief Payments

Item	Condition	Payer	Amount
Investigation retainer	Credible evidence delivered	Mara Vey's family trust	250 gp
Watch reward	Civilians protected and breach contained	Captain Dane	500 gp
Archive warrant	Voss testifies	City archive	Access / political leverage
Milestone	Survive and resolve the Seventh Ward crisis	—	Earned — apply between sessions only

Tone / Staging Beats

- Rain gets quieter whenever the ash clock advances.
- No victim is grotesque: the horror is bureaucratic indifference and a wrong expression.
- Let archive dust mimic ash until the players test it.
- Vorthax never shouts; it speaks like a clerk correcting a form.
- Mirrors show a reflection one heartbeat late before they show anything impossible.

Loose Ends to Flag in Session Log After Play

- [] Which victims' names and records were restored?
- [] Did Elian Voss testify, flee, die, or accept custody?
- [] Did Captain Dane keep command of the Watch?
- [] Was Vorthax destroyed, banished, bargained with, or unleashed?
- [] Did the party publish, seal, or destroy the Hall's records?
- [] Which Veyrhaven faction now owes or opposes the party?